*BY ORDER OF THE SECRETARY OF THE AIR FORCE*

*HEADQUARTERS OPERATING INSTRUCTION 35-1*

*28 JULY 2026*

***Public Affairs***

***PUBLIC AFFAIRS MANAGEMENT***

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This HOI implements Department of the Air Force Policy Directive (DAFPD) 35-1, *Public Affairs Management*, and must be used in conjunction with Department of the Air Force Instruction (DAFI) 35-101, *Public Affairs Operations* and Air Force Manual (AFMAN) 35-101, *Public Affairs Procedures*. It establishes procedures and standards for the management of the Headquarters Department of the Air Force Air and Space Forces Civic Leader Program. It explains the program procedures and execution information. This instruction is applicable to all personnel at the DAF who are involved with the HQ DAF Civic Leader Program across the HAF staff. Refer recommended changes and questions about this publication to the Office of Primary Responsibility (OPR) using the DAF Form 847, Recommendation for Change of Publication, and forward to the Air Force Departmental Publications Office (AFDPO), Policy, Plans and Programs (PPX) at **SAF.AA.AFDPOPPX.Workflow@us.af.mil**. Ensure that all records generated as a result of processes prescribed in this publication adhere to *Air Force Instruction 33-322*, Records Management and Information Governance Program, and are disposed of in accordance with the Air Force Records Disposition Schedule which is located in the Air Force Records Information Management System.

## 1. Overview.

### 1.1. Headquarters Operating Instruction (HOI) 35-1.

1.1.1. This Headquarters Operating Instruction (HOI) defines Department of the Air Force (DAF) procedures and responsibilities of DAF offices involved in the Headquarters Department of the Air and Space Forces Civic Leader Program, also known as the HQ DAF Civic Leader Program.

1.1.2. The HQ DAF Civic Leader Program augments the partnership between local communities and their own civic leaders, and senior DAF leadership across the nation.

1.1.3. It enables the DAF to maintain a cadre of community leaders to educate and leverage key influencer audiences on DAF missions and priorities.

1.1.4. It augments MAJCOM/FLDCOM and installation level Civic Leader Programs.

## 2. Roles and Responsibilities.

### 2.1. The Secretary of the Air Force (SecAF) shall:

2.1.1. Appoint HQ DAF Civic Leaders to participate in the Air and Space Forces Civic Leader Program representing DAF communities and equities.

2.1.2. Regularly engage with the group to identify key DAF priorities and opportunities for civic leader advocacy and engagement.

2.2. The Chief of Staff of the Air Force (CSAF) shall:

2.2.1. Appoint the HQ DAF Civic Leaders to participate in the program representing Air Force communities and equities.

2.2.2. Regularly engage with the group to identify key Air Force priorities and opportunities for civic leader advocacy and engagement.

2.3. The Chief of Space Operations (CSO) shall:

2.3.1. Appoint HQ DAF Civic Leaders representing Space Force communities and equities.

2.3.2. Regularly engage with the group to identify key Space Force priorities and opportunities for civic leader advocacy and engagement.

2.4. Secretary of the Air Force Public Affairs (SAF/PA) shall:

2.4.1. Manage the HQ DAF Civic Leader program on behalf of the SecAF, CSAF and CSO.

2.4.2. Oversee the nomination, selection, and notification processes.

2.4.3. Communicate with members; plan meeting/events and logistics; and coordinate official travel. Planning will include two in-person HQ DAF Civic Leader engagements per fiscal year.

2.5. Administration and Management (SAF/AA) shall:

2.5.1. Manage the funding of HQ DAF Civic Leaders' travel, in coordination with SAF/PA.

2.5.1.1. This includes both the allocation of resources and the reimbursement of expenses, determined by the nature of the event.

2.5.2. SAF/AA will fund at least two civic leader events per year.

2.6. The Air Force General Counsel (SAF/GC) shall:

2.6.1. Provide advice to the Secretariat on *Standards of Ethical Conduct* matters and other issues involving the HQ DAF Civic Leader program.

2.6.2. Conduct the ethics brief for new Civic Leaders.

2.7. The Judge Advocate General (AF/JA) shall:

2.7.1. Advise CSAF and CSO on the appointment of Civic Leaders and the administration of the HQ DAF Civic Leader Program.

2.8. Air Mobility Command Public Affairs (AMC/PA) shall:

2.8.1. Fund military airlift requirements on behalf of SAF/PA in accordance with *Passenger Movement* AFI 24-602v1, section 3.19.

2.8.1.1. Typically, one HQ DAF Civic Leader event per year is held in the National Capital Region (NCR), and coordination for one military airlift outside the NCR is required.

**3. HQ DAF Civic Leader Roles and Responsibilities, Status, and Terms of Service.**

3.1. HQ DAF Civic Leader roles. Appointment letters to HQ DAF Civic Leaders will ask that they:

3.1.1. Provide individual advice and information to the CSAF, CSO, and commanders at all levels on matters relating to public issues involving the DAF and its operations.

3.1.2. Disseminate information about the DAF's objectives, roles, requirements, and major programs to the public through public speeches, personal contact, and other means.

3.1.3. Provide individual advice concerning the development of programs and methods to attain maximum understanding and cooperation between the affected civilian communities and the DAF.

3.1.4. Disseminate information to appropriate MAJCOM/FLDCOM and base civic leader councils and other similar groups in which they may participate.

3.1.5. Educate and inform key national, state, and local stakeholders and policymakers on DAF priorities, initiatives, and shortfalls.

3.1.5.1. The purpose of these interactions is to foster a greater understanding of the DAF.

3.1.5.2. HQ DAF Civic Leaders act independently, providing their own perspectives and insights based upon their understanding of the information provided to them by the DAF.

3.1.6. Will not be recognized, or hold themselves out, as official DAF employees.

3.1.6.1. HQ DAF Civic Leaders do not officially represent the DAF and do not have the authority to bind the DAF to any agreements or promises. Neither the DAF nor the civic leader should imply the presence of a special relationship with, or preferential treatment for, any business or organization with whom the civic leader is affiliated.

3.2. HQ DAF Civic Leader status.

3.2.1. HQ DAF Civic Leaders serve in their individual capacities without salary, wages, or related benefits.

3.2.1.1. They will not be appointed as special government employees (SGEs) and will not receive security clearances.

3.2.1.2. HQ DAF Civic Leaders will not be asked to file public or confidential financial disclosure reports but may be asked to voluntarily complete and submit an informational confidential financial disclosure report (OGE Form 450) upon initial appointment and upon request.

3.2.2. For protocol purposes only, HQ DAF Civic Leaders are considered 3-star equivalents.

3.2.3. Civic leaders will be issued invitational travel authorizations (ITAs) in accordance with the Joint Travel Regulations (JTR).

3.2.3.1. They may be reimbursed for official travel expenses (transportation, per diem, etc.) while attending HQ DAF Civic Leader meetings or events in accordance with the JTR.

3.2.3.2. They can also choose to pay for their own expenses.

3.2.3.3. Any participation in HQ DAF Civic Leader Program events by the spouses or guests of the Civic Leaders will not be at the government’s expense.

3.3. Civic leader term of office.

3.3.1. Civic leaders are asked to serve for four years in an active status and thereafter in the emeritus program.

3.3.1.1. On behalf of senior leadership, SAF/PA can extend a civic leader in active status for two additional four-year terms if it is beneficial to the DAF. Most civic leaders who routinely engage in supporting the DAF serve for eight years.

3.3.2. No civic leader will serve more than three terms.

3.3.3. Once a civic leader completes all appointed terms, they are placed in emeritus status.

3.4. Civic leader mentors.

3.4.1. SAF/PA will nominate three HQ DAF Civic Leaders to serve as mentors to guide incoming civic leaders and act as a liaison between the DAF and the larger civic leader program members.

3.4.2. HQ DAF Civic Leaders will not exceed eight years in the mentor role.

3.5. Transition to Emeritus Status.

3.5.1. Following a civic leader's transition to emeritus status, the DAF will maintain engagement provided that both parties desire to continue the partnership and doing so remains in the best interest of the DAF.

3.5.2. Upon completing their active term, civic leaders who have met an appropriate standard of engagement will be considered to receive the Distinguished Public Service Award (DPSA) for their service.

3.5.2.1. SAF/PA, in consultation with other stakeholders, will determine which civic leaders have met the standard established by DoDI 1400.25v451_DAFI36-1004 to receive the award.

3.5.2.2. Factors to be considered include level of engagement by the civic leader, specific actions they took in support of the DAF, and overall impact in supporting DAF priorities.

3.5.2.3. SAF/PA will coordinate requests for DPSAs through SAF/AA to the SecAF for approval.

3.5.2.4. Because HQ DAF Civic Leaders are in direct correspondence with SecAF, CSAF, CSO and DAF senior leaders and often contribute advice and counsel in confidence, a standardized citation will be used.

3.5.3. SAF/PA will provide updates to emeritus civic leaders.

3.5.3.1. Emeritus civic leaders will be invited, at their own expense, to the annual conference in the NCR.

3.5.3.2. Emeritus civic leaders may be included in program trips to installations outside the NCR on a space-available basis after all active civic leaders have had the opportunity to participate.

## 4. HQ DAF Civic Leader Appointment Process and Selection Criteria.

### 4.1. HQ DAF Civic Leader appointments.

4.1.1. The CSAF and CSO appoint individuals to serve as HQ DAF Civic Leaders.

4.1.1.1. The SecAF can nominate additional HQ DAF Civic Leaders at his/her discretion.

4.1.1.2. The total number of active HQ DAF Civic Leaders should not exceed 40.

4.1.1.3. HQ DAF Civic Leaders serve in a volunteer capacity as governed by Title 10 of the United States Code, Section 1588 - *Authority to accept certain voluntary services* and DoDI 1100.21 *Voluntary Services in the Department of Defense.*

4.1.2. SAF/PA will determine an appropriate apportionment to ensure representation for both Air Force and Space Force.

4.1.3. The HQ DAF Civic Leader Program is comprised of one (1) civic leader from each nominated MAJCOM/FLDCOM and the National Guard Bureau. In addition, Headquarters Air Force and Headquarters Space Force can directly appoint a total of 7-10 at-large civic leaders.

4.1.4. MAJCOM/FLDCOM nominations for HQ DAF Civic Leader appointments occur every two years with half of the commands nominating during one cycle and the remaining commands nominating the following cycle. SAF/PA will ensure that MAJCOMs/FLDCOMs understand the nomination cycle and timeline.

4.2. Regional and At-Large HQ DAF Civic Leaders.

4.2.1. Regional Civic Leaders.

4.2.1.1. To ensure appropriate regional input, the majority of HQ DAF Civic Leaders will be appointed based on their influence and expertise in a particular region. MAJCOM and FLDCOM commander input will guide these selections.

4.2.2. At-Large Civic Leaders.

4.2.2.1. At the discretion of SecAF, CSAF and CSO, a limited number of HQ DAF Civic Leaders may be appointed on an "at-large" basis because of experience, expertise, or other unique capabilities that make their participation valuable to the DAF.

4.3. HQ DAF Civic Leader criteria for selection.

4.3.1. Each individual selected should:

4.3.1.1. Be a United States citizen of outstanding character, integrity, and patriotism.

4.3.1.2. Have a deep interest in military affairs.

4.3.1.3. Be a leader in local/regional community affairs.

4.3.1.4. Be in a position to disseminate information about the DAF to a broad cross section of the public and to other prominent citizens in his or her area.

4.3.1.5. Be able to interpret public attitude and educate public audiences on the DAF.

4.3.1.6. Not be an employee of the Federal Government as defined in 5 USC § 2105.

4.3.1.7. Not be a Federal elected or campaigning for election, or appointed official or a member of their staff. State and local elected or appointed officials will be considered on a case-by-case basis.

4.3.1.8. Not be an active member of any military service, National Guard or a member of the Ready Reserve (Selected), Individual Ready Reserve, or Standby Reserve.

4.3.1.9. Not be a paid employee of any political party, political club, or other political organization.

4.3.1.10. Not be a retired service member. Former military service will not be considered disqualifying.

4.3.1.11. Not be a director, officer, or employee of a for-profit entity that does business with the DAF, seeks to do business with the DAF, or directs its business at Airmen, Guardians or military families.

4.3.2. SAF/PA, with the assistance of SAF/DS as needed, will identify and evaluate information on prospective nominees, including whether any potentially disqualifying conditions exist, and will forward appointment recommendations to the CSAF and CSO for their final approval. When appropriate, SAF/PA will ask MAJCOM/FLDCOM commanders for additional candidates.

4.4. Nominations.

4.4.1. SAF/PA will collect the following information to be considered by the CSAF and CSO for open positions:

4.4.1.1. MAJCOM/FLDCOM commanders' nominations, including any listing of preference.

4.4.1.2. A biography/curriculum vitae for each nominee.

4.4.1.3. An evaluation by SAF/PA concerning the personal qualifications of each nominee, using the criteria outlined in this HOI.

4.4.1.4. Any solicited or unsolicited letters of recommendation.

4.4.1.5. An evaluation of which candidates are best positioned to support the DAF based on all factors and the needs of the program.

4.4.1.6. AF/JA will review proposed nominations through relevant databases to ensure there is no known adverse information on the nominee.

4.5. Out of cycle vacancies.

4.5.1. When vacancies occur other than by expiration of term of appointment (i.e., as the result of resignation or removal), SAF/PA, in coordination with the MAJCOMs, FLDCOMs, Office of the Chief of Staff, and Office of the Chief of Space Operations may submit nominations of replacement members, listed in order of preference. Vacancies will be filled at the discretion of SAF/PA in order to meet the program objectives.

4.5.2. Selection procedures for initial appointment are as follows:

4.5.2.1. When SecAF, CSAF and/or CSO select a HQ DAF Civic Leader for an initial term, SAF/PA will notify the individual to confirm the willingness to accept the appointment. SAF/PA will:

4.5.2.1.1. Inform the candidate that CSAF or CSO will send a letter formally offering an appointment.

4.5.2.1.2. Arrange for initial orientation on ethics/standards of conduct.

4.5.3. Upon acceptance by the candidate, a formal letter of appointment will be signed by the CSAF/CSO and delivered by SAF/PA to the civic leader.

## 5. Standards of Conduct and Disqualifying Conditions:

5.1. **Process for Removal.**

5.1.1. Should continue participation of a HQ DAF Civic Leader be deemed not in the best interest of the DAF, SAF/PA maintains the discretionary ability to remove HQ DAF Civic Leaders after obtaining approval from the nominating source (SecAF, CSAF, or CSO as appropriate) in coordination with SAF/GC or AF/JA, as appropriate.

5.1.2. SAF/PA will manage the removal process once approval has been provided from the nominating source. Removal of Emeritus Civic Leaders from further participation is authorized at the SAF/PA director level, with notification to DAF leadership.

**6. Interaction with DAF Civic Leaders.**

6.1. **Communication.**

6.1.1. The CSAF and CSO will communicate directly with HQ DAF Civic Leaders.

6.1.2. SAF/PA will provide information to the civic leaders in a weekly e-mail.

6.1.3. Other DAF officials who would like to send information to HQ DAF Civic Leaders will coordinate with SAF/PA prior to doing so.

6.1.4. In no case will a HQ DAF Civic Leader's name be placed on a mailing list without the civic leader's advance written permission or without authorization from SAF/PA.

6.2. Recurring HQ DAF Civic Leader Events.

6.2.1. The DAF will host an annual conference in the NCR in the Spring to provide the HQ DAF Civic Leaders with updates from key leaders to guide their engagements during the year.

6.2.2. DAF will organize one field event yearly for HQ DAF Civic Leaders in active status, to be held at Air Force or Space Force installations outside the NCR. SAF/PA will limit engagements outside CONUS to no more than once every two years. The two in-person annual engagements will be funded by SAF/AA in coordination with SAF/PA. The number of escorts for the field event should not exceed eight, with allocation to be determined by the director of SAF/PA. The senior escort will be at a minimum of an O-6 or equivalent.

6.2.3. HQ DAF Civic Leaders will be issued ITAs for travel to and from events directed and approved by the CSAF or CSO, in accordance with the JTR.

6.2.3.1. Unless otherwise authorized, travel will be by commercial carrier, and premium class travel accommodations are not authorized without advance approval, both as specified in the JTR.

6.2.3.2. The use of military airlift for HQ DAF Civic Leader program travel will be processed and approved per DAFI 24-602 Vol 1.

6.2.3.3. HQ DAF Civic Leader Program participants may modify ITA travel arrangements, at no additional cost to the government, to attend optional DAF-affiliated information, ceremonial, and social events.

6.2.3.4. Participation in HQ DAF Civic Leader Program events is automatically deemed the provision of a direct service to the government, as defined in JTR Section 030501.A.12. Issuance of ITAs is contingent upon meeting JTR criteria and associated statutes and is subject to the availability of funding. All travel will adhere to the guidelines outlined in the JTR.

6.2.4. Virtual Update Meetings.

6.2.4.1. The DAF will schedule monthly virtual updates with the civic leaders, subject to current events and priorities.

6.2.5. Other events.

6.2.5.1. At the direction of the SecAF, CSAF, or CSO, HQ DAF Civic Leaders may be requested to support additional events. Civic leader participation will be coordinated by SAF/AA.

6.2.5.2. HQ DAF Civic leaders will be considered "prominent U.S. Citizens" for Official Representation Funds (ORF) eligibility purposes in accordance with DAFI 65-603, *Emergency and Extraordinary Expense Authority*.

6.3. Coordination.

6.3.1. Coordination with SAF/PA and the Office of the CSAF and Office of the CSO is required on actions pertaining to the HQ DAF Civic Leader Program. HQ DAF Civic Leaders are encouraged to continue to play active roles in MAJCOM, FLDCOM, and local civic leader programs.

6.3.2. DAF actions with an impact on individual HQ DAF Civic Leaders or on the administration of the HQ DAF Civic Leader Program will be coordinated with SAF/PA (e.g., scheduling conflicts, funding issues).

6.3.3. SAF/PA will send a budget request for the program to SAF/AA by June indicating expected costs for the upcoming fiscal year. SAF/AA will coordinate line of accounting (LOA) with the SAF/PA Director of Staff office at the start of the fiscal year.

6.3.4. SAF/PA will request airlift through Air Mobility Command Public Affairs for the field event no later than two months prior to event execution.

TIMOTHY A. HERRITAGE,
Brigadier General, USAF
Director, Public Affairs

**Attachment 1**

**GLOSSARY OF REFERENCES AND SUPPORTING INFORMATION**

***References***

*Joint Travel Regulations* (Available at **http://www.dtic.mil/whs/directives/corres/otherdocs.html**)

A related publication is a source of additional information. *The user does not have to read the related publication to understand this publication.*

*Joint Ethics Regulation,* 15 May 2024. (Available at **http://www.dod.mil/dodgc/defense_ethics/**) Air Force Manual 65-605, Volume 1, *Budget Guidance and Technical Procedures*, 26 November 2019

AFI 33-332, *Privacy Act Program*, 29 January 2004.

Title 5 Code of Federal Regulations Part 2635, *Standards of Ethical Conduct for Employees of the Executive Branch* (Available at **http://www.gpoaccess.gov/cfr/index.html**)

Executive Order 12731, Principles of Ethical Conduct for Government Officers and Employees. (Available at **http://www.usoge.gov/laws_regs/exec_orders/eo12731.pdf**)

Title 5 United States Code Section 2105 (Available at **http://www.gpoaccess.gov/uscode/index.html**)

Title 5 United States Code Section 8101 et seq. *Federal Employees Compensation Act.*

**(Available at http://www.gpoaccess.gov/uscode/index.html)** Title 18 United States Code Section 202(a) (Available at **http://www.gpoaccess.gov/uscode/index.html**)

DoDI 1400.25v451_DAFI36-1004 *Department Of The Air Force Civilian Recognition Program*, 18 December 2023

10 U.S. Code § 1588 - *Authority to Accept Certain Voluntary Services*

DoDI 1100.21 DOD INSTRUCTION 1100.21 *Voluntary Services in the Department of Defense,*

March 27, 2019

DAFI 65-603, *Emergency and Extraordinary Expense Authority, 29 April 2020. Joint Travel Regulations,* 1 January 2024

DAFPD 35-1: *Department of the Air Force Policy Directive 35-1, Public Affairs Management*, 23 December 2020

DAFI 24-602, V1: *Department of the Air Force Instruction 24-602, Volume 1, Passenger Movement,* 15 December 2020

DAFMAN 35-101*: Department of the Air Force Manual 35-101, Public Affairs Procedures,* 9 April 2020

***Abbreviations and Acronyms***

**CONUS**—Continental United States

**DPSA**—Distinguished Public Service Award

**ITA**—Invitational Travel Authorization

**JTR**—Joint Travel Regulation

**LOA** – Line of Accounting

**NCR** – National Capital Region

**OGE**—U.S. Office of Government Ethics

**ORF**—Official Representation Funds